



Workshop: Backing up Data

To protect against the growing threat of viruses, and the morbid fear that your hard drives might crash, backing up regularly is an exercise you can ill afford to avoid. But it can be a chore that even the most dedicated computer users procrastinate, often until it's too late.

So if a software eradicates this drudgery, and entices us into becoming committed 'backers', it's definitely worth a few hundred rupees.

Second Copy 2000 from Centered Systems (www.centered.com) is one such program. Add a list of the files you want to back up, and it copies these automatically to a destination of your choice. In networked environments, you can select to back up data to another PC. In a computer with two hard drives, you can mirror the data on the other drive, since it's highly unlikely that both machines and both hard disks will fail at the same time.

Second Copy organises your backup needs into profiles. Each profile defines the set of files or folders that you want to copy, the location where you want to copy these files to, and the frequency of backups. Click on the File

menu and select New Profile. This will bring up the New Profile Wizard window, from where you can select either Express setup or Custom setup. Express setup, as the name suggests, is really easy to use, and you need only answer three basic questions (What, Where and When). Once configured, Second Copy monitors the source folder (What) for changes or updates, and copies new or changed files to the destination folder (Where) automatically at the scheduled time (When). Alternatively, you can create a new profile by simply dragging the folder you want to back up into the Second Copy application window.



Second Copy's Profile Wizard eases the task of data backups

Glossary

Tracks and sectors: A hard disk consists of platters on which data is stored. These platters consist of tens of thousands of tracks that are tightly integrated in concentric circles. Tracks are broken down into sectors. Hence, a sector is the smallest addressable unit on a hard disk.

S.M.A.R.T: Self-Monitoring Analysis and Reporting Tool. This system uses internal hard disk monitoring technology to analyse your hard disk, and prevent failure or data loss.

Bad sector: A sector that cannot be used due to a physical flaw on the disk is called a bad sector.

Clusters: A cluster is a logical unit of storage on a hard disk or floppy drive. The size of a cluster varies from 512 bytes to 256 KB, depending on the file system and on the size of the

partition.

FAT: File Allocation Table. The FAT tells the OS which portions of the disk belong to which file. The FAT links together all the clusters belonging to each file, no matter where they are on the disk.

Partition: By default, when a hard disk is formatted, it has one partition. A partition can be considered a formatted section of a hard disk. Large hard disks can be formatted into multiple partitions, and each partition behaves like an individual, or separate, hard drive.

Boot disk: A special floppy, known as a boot disk, allows your PC to boot, even if it cannot boot from the hard disk. Such a disk is also known as a System Rescue Disk.